Atlético Madrid

Griezmann Replacement Analysis

Football Recruitment Analytics | Top 5 European Leagues | 2024/25 & 2025/26

2,854
Players Analysed

53
Cross-Season Overlap

4
Final Candidates

Hugo Ortega-Morales | April 2025

The Problem

BUSINESS PROBLEM

Antoine Griezmann is leaving Atlético Madrid after a decade — confirmed heading to Orlando City at the end of the 2025/26 season. His departure removes the connective tissue of Simeone's system.

Griezmann was never a pure goalscorer or a pure creator. He operated across every attacking dimension simultaneously — linking midfield to attack, creating chances at an elite level, and contributing to the team’s defensive function. Replacing a complete profile is rare, and this analysis intends to find the closest available solution.

Structural Void

Ability to fill the false 9 / SS role and of more recent operating as free roam 10 / 8 — rare profile to find

Profile Complexity

Creation, progression, goal threat, and defensive work ethic all in one player

Recruitment Risk

Wrong signing wastes transfer budget and sets unnecessary risk

AIM

Use 2024/25 and 2025/26 football data to identify players who most closely replicate Griezmann's statistical profile across the top 5 European leagues — delivering an evidence-based shortlist for the 2026 summer window.

Methodology

Benchmark Construction & Candidate Pool

2025/26 season abandoned — managed minutes distorted profile. 2024/25 (2,469 min) adopted as benchmark. Candidate pool consisted of FW/MF players with age and minute requirements.

Cosine Similarity

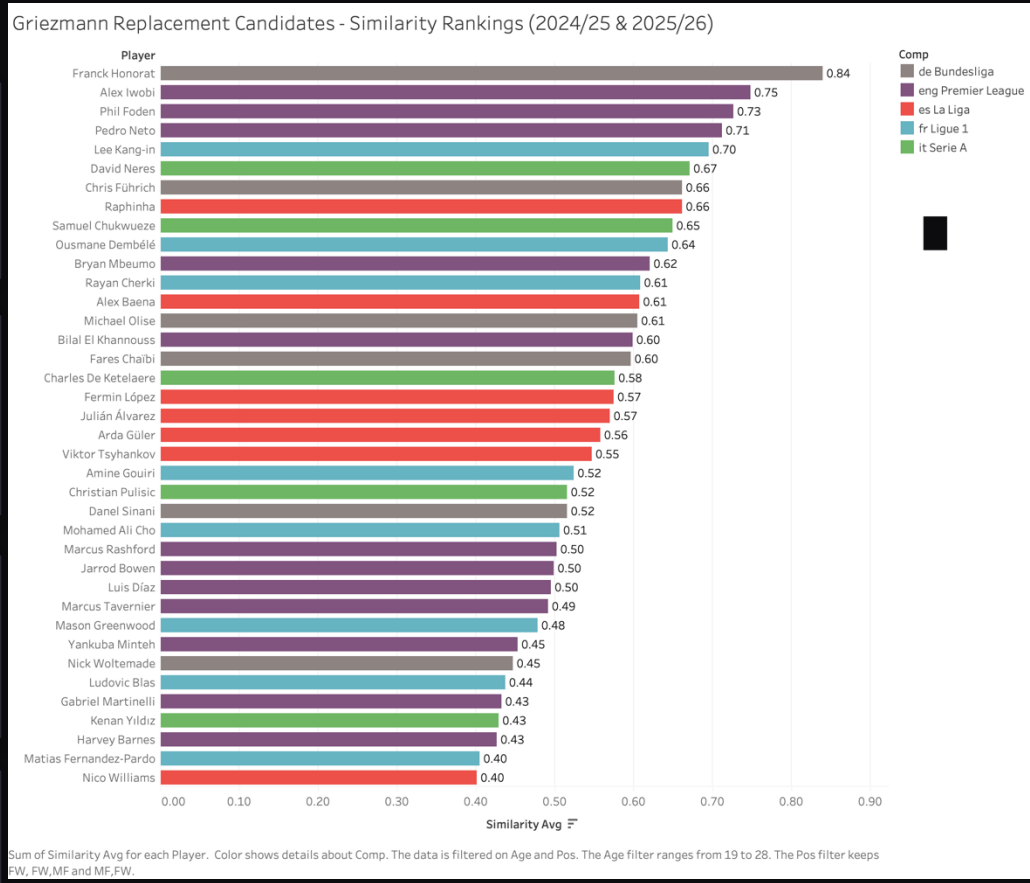
StandardScaler normalizes statistical values. Cosine similarity develops similarity profile profiles across candidate pool.

Scatter Analysis

Goal Threat vs Creativity + Similarity vs Output Level — proxy for missing positional heatmap data.

Radar Profiling

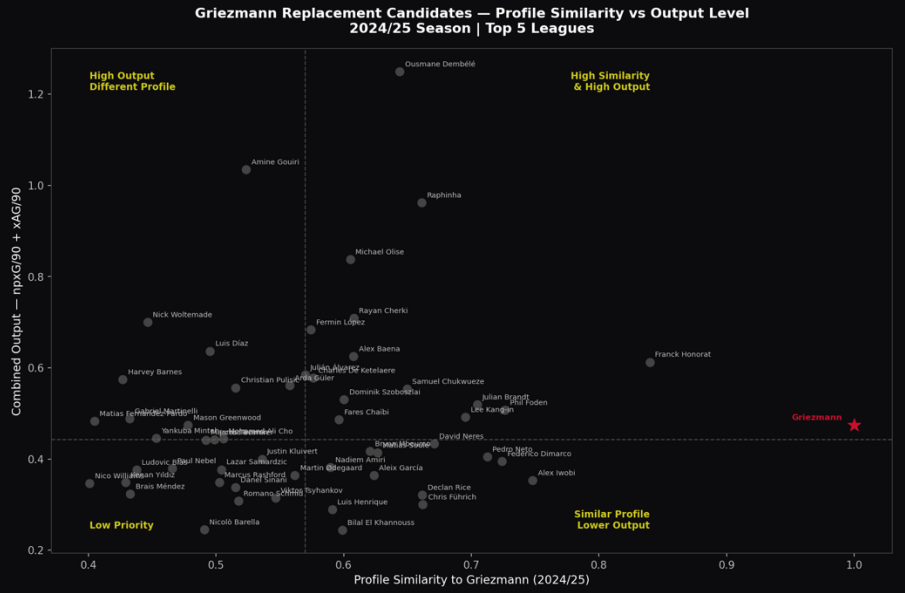
Percentile ranks vs 826-player pool. 5-axis composite + 20-metric detailed radar per candidate.

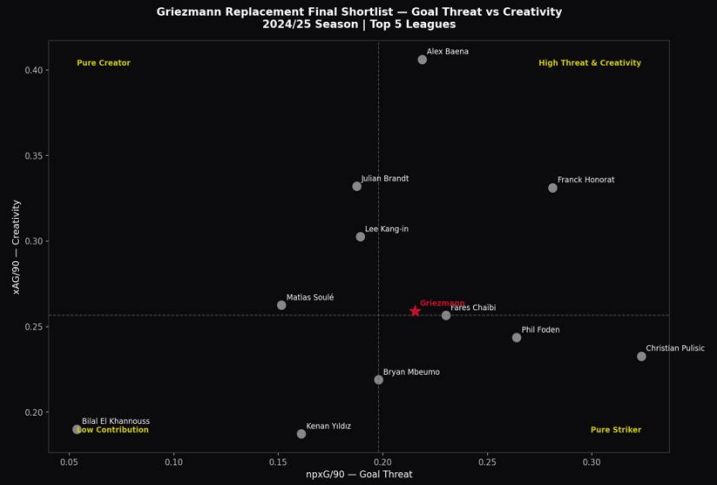


Key Finding

Griezmann's balanced profile across chance creation, goal threat, ball progression, and defensive contribution is genuinely rare. The performance vs profile scatter plot backs this finding.

GRIEZMANN 2024/25 — COMPOSITE PERCENTILE PROFILE





Recommendations

PRIORITY ORDER — FINAL FOUR CANDIDATES

01 **Alex Baena** Atlético Madrid | Age 24 **The Replacement is Already at Home**

KP/90 at 99.8th percentile. SCA/90 at 99th. xAG/90 at 99.2nd. Highest chance creation profile of any candidate. Currently misused as a channel forward — repositioned in the Griezmann role, the data makes the case before the club spends externally.

02 **Lee Kang-in** Paris Saint-Germain | Age 25 **Primary External Target**

Closest statistical profile match to Griezmann in the dataset. KP/90, PPA/90, SCA/90, xAG/90 all top 1-3% of pool. Genuine transfer links — Atlético sporting director Alemany reportedly in discussions.

03 **Phil Foden** Manchester City | Age 25 **The Ambitious Hidden Gem**

Highest goal threat of the four finalists. Situation at City mirrors conditions that made Julián Álvarez available. No transfer links at time of writing — but if the door opens, the data backs walking through it.

04 **Matías Soulé** Roma | Age 23 **One to Monitor**

Elite ball progression at 21 — PrgC/90 91.6th percentile, PrgR/90 93.3rd. Similar finishing quality gap to Baena makes him a lower priority with Baena already in the squad. High ceiling, track closely.

01 — Alex Baena

THE REPLACEMENT IS ALREADY AT HOME

The most statistically compelling finding of this analysis. Baena's chance creation profile is the highest of any candidate in the dataset. His concern this season has been positional — deployed as a channel forward rather than the free-roaming creative role his data says he belongs in.
Before spending in the market, trust what is already in the squad.

⚠ Finishing Quality gap (SoT% 22.9 vs Griezmann 58.5) — improvable area at age 24. Radar comparison and Wyscout validation recommended before final decision.

99.8th	99.0th	99.2nd
KP/90	**SCA/90**	**xAG/90**
Percentile	Percentile	Percentile

Baena vs Griezmann — Detailed Profile
2024/25 Season | Percentile Ranks vs FW/MF Pool

02 — Lee Kang-in

PRIMARY EXTERNAL TARGET

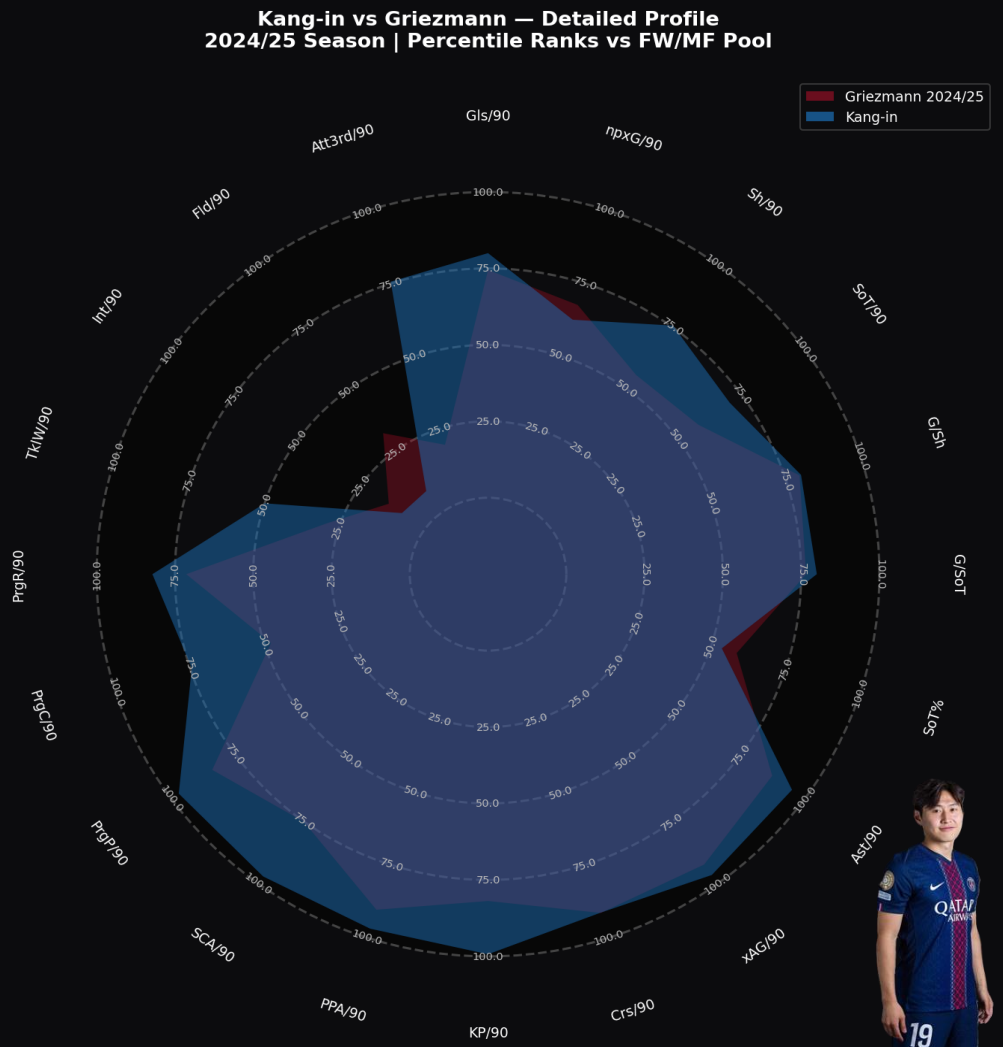
Paris Saint-Germain | Age 25 | Ligue 1

Statistically the closest profile match to Griezmann in the dataset. His chance creation numbers are exceptional — KP/90, PPA/90, SCA/90, and xAG/90 all rank in the top 1-3% of the 826-player pool.

Transfer links already exist with Atlético sporting director Alemany reportedly involved in discussions. The defensive contribution gap is manageable given Simeone's track record of instilling defensive discipline. Age 25 gives the club a player who can grow into the role.

⚠ Defensive contribution gap (TklW/90 at 50th percentile, Int/90 at 9th). PSG's system more possession based influencing his defensive contributions.

99.3rd	96.6th	0.695
KP/90	xAG/90	Sim. Score
Percentile	Percentile	Avg Similarity



03 — Phil Foden

THE AMBITIOUS HIDDEN GEM

Manchester City | Age 25 | Premier League

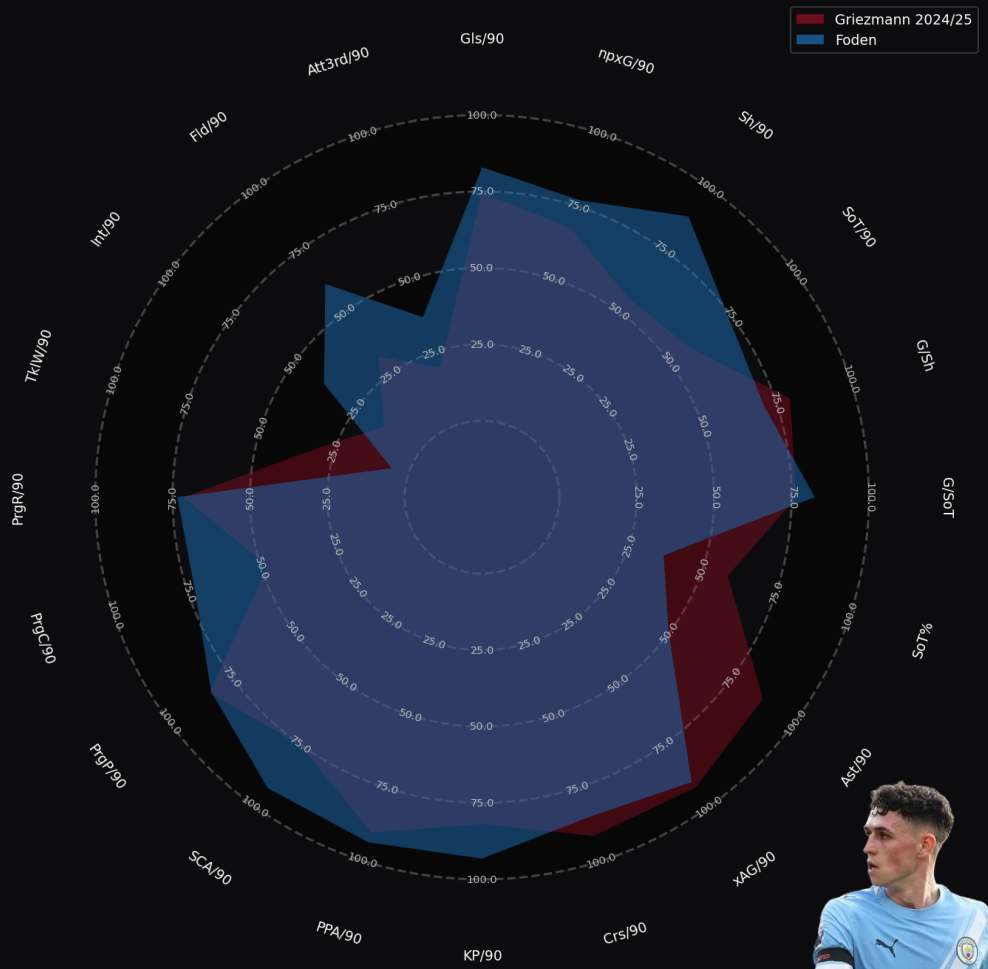
Included not as a super-realistic target but as a statistically backed case for a bold summer approach. Highest goal threat of the four finalists — Gls/90 at 82.9th percentile, npxG/90 at 77.1st, Sh/90 at 88.5th — combined with elite chance creation across KP/90, PPA/90, and SCA/90.

His situation at City — rotating minutes and an uncertain role— mirrors the conditions that made Julián Álvarez available. No transfer links at time of writing. If the door opens, Atlético should walk through it. Don't be surprised when it does.

⚠ TkIW/90 at 5.7th percentile — significant defensive contribution gap. Like Kang-in Lee, playing in a possession-based team.

82.9th	93.2nd	88.5th
Gls/90	KP/90	Sh/90
Percentile	Percentile	Percentile

Foden vs Griezmann — Detailed Profile
2024/25 Season | Percentile Ranks vs FW/MF Pool



04 — Matías Soulé

ONE TO MONITOR

Roma | Age 23 | Serie A

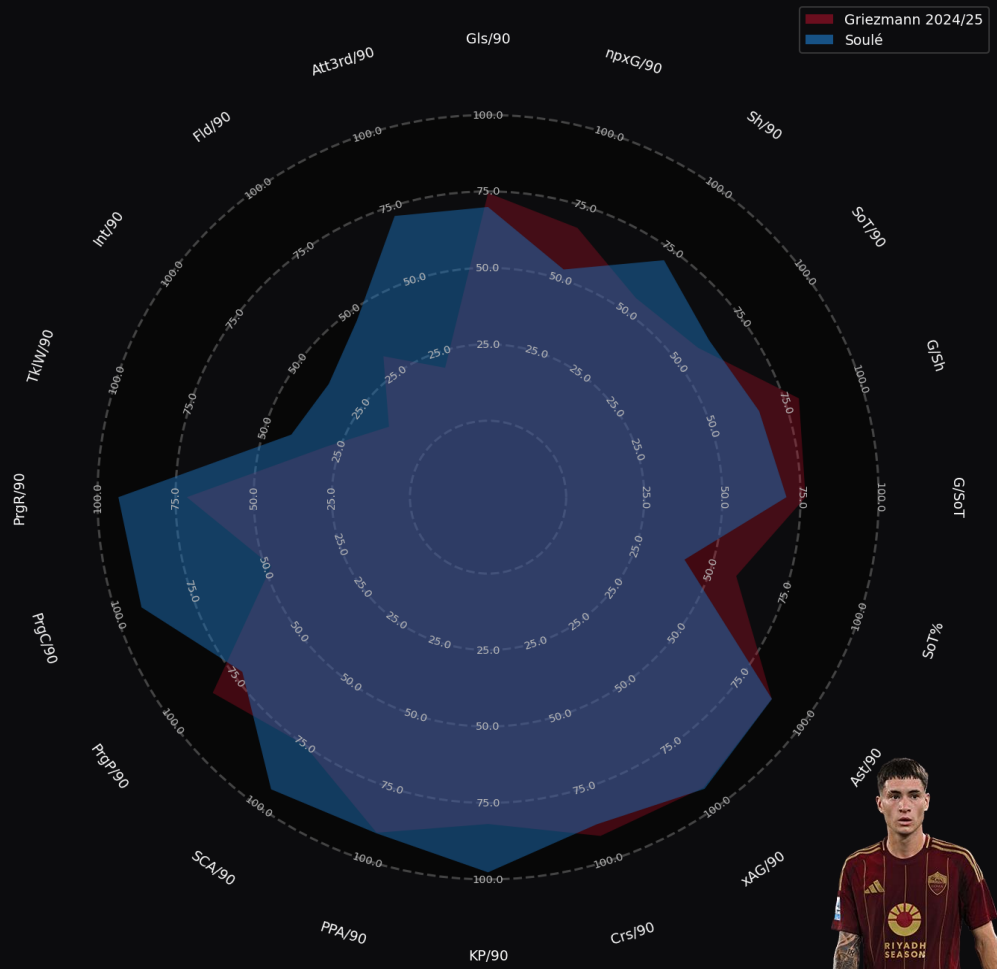
At 23, Soulé profiles as an elite ball progressor — PrgC/90 at 91.6th percentile, PrgR/90 at 93.3rd — showing an ability to carry and receive the ball in dangerous areas that complements the needed profile. Chance creation percentile range across multiple metrics confirms he is playing at a high level despite his age.

However, with Baena already at the club carrying a similar finishing quality gap relative to Griezmann, the case for bringing in another player with the same limitation is difficult to make at this stage. Strong profile, high ceiling —but prioritise behind the other three.

⚠ Similar finishing quality gap to Baena (SoT% 41.1 vs Griezmann 58.5). Baena's presence in the squad reduces urgency of this signing.

91.6th	93.1st	93.3rd
PrgC/90	**SCA/90**	**PrgR/90**
Percentile	Percentile	Percentile

Soulé vs Griezmann — Detailed Profile
2024/25 Season | Percentile Ranks vs FW/MF Pool



Next Steps & Limitations

NEXT STEPS

Wyscout Integration

Video analysis of final four to validate statistical findings

PCA-Weighted Composites

Data-driven feature weights within each composite bucket rather than unweighted averages.

Historical Benchmark

Rerun using Griezmann's historical profile to identify candidates who replicate peak output rather than evolved role.

LIMITATIONS

No Positional Heatmap Data

FBref's broad FW/MF tags required scatter plots as proxy filter. Spatial tracking data would significantly improve precision.

Unweighted Composite Scores

Each metric contributes equally. PCA-derived weights would better reflect relative importance within each category.

2025/26 Dataset Scope

Missing npxG, progressive passes, SCA, PPA — constrained cross-season comparison to reduced feature set.

Benchmark Season Caveat

2024/25 reflects an evolved Griezmann. His 2022-2024 peak profile would produce a different shortlist.